

## Fake Intro

1 [Fade in a picture of Tolkien] John Ronald Reuel /ru:l/ Tolkien is a man who probably needs no  
2 introduction. He is considered by many as the father of modern fantasy literature; most know him by  
3 his most famous works, *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings*, which have left a profound impact on  
4 the fantasy genre. Some of you might know him as a professor of English Language and Literature or  
5 from his work around Old English, the most famous of which is probably his translation of the Anglo-  
6 Saxon epic *Beowulf*.

7 However, since you're watching this video, the part of Tolkien's work that you are probably most  
8 interested in is his conlangs, among which the Elvish languages of Quenya and Sindarin are probably  
9 the most well-known.

10 But today's video isn't a biography of Tolkien's life, so without further ado, let's take a look at Elvish!  
11 [show slide with 'Elvish' in the centre]

12 [TODO: The intro could probably be improved quite a bit...]

## Fake Phonology + Sentence

13 As ever, let's start by talking about the phonology of Elvish. The table here shows the Elvish consonant  
14 phoneme inventory [Show Sindarin phoneme table]. The consonants are [start reading the conso-  
15 nants, up to the middle of the 'stop' row, then interrupt]... wait hold on that doesn't look right. Er...  
16 [1/2 second pause], I think I got the wrong table. Where did I... Er, whatever, I bet y'all are tired of  
17 conlang reviews starting off with the phonology section anyway.

18 Y'know reading out sounds is nice and all, but I feel like in order to get a proper understanding of the  
19 language, we should start with a sentence so we can fully appreciate the elegance and euphony of the  
20 Elvish language. Recently, I gave our Discord members a short sentence in Elvish and asked them to  
21 provide their best attempt at a rendition of it. This is what I got [Play everyone's audio clips as usual].

22 What can I say, an attempt was made I suppose. Sorry guys, but you got it all wrong, though I saw some  
23 of you caught on to what was happening this time when we didn't provide any IPA, but the *correct* way  
24 to pronounce this sentence is obviously [Show slide w/ IPA and read the sentence].

25 Isn't that beautiful? Euphonic? Now, if you're a bit confused about my pronunciation just now, that  
26 wasn't because I'm really bad at Sindarin, or Quenya. No, this is *Elvish*; except that the Elves we're  
27 talking about here... are not Tolkien's Elves. No, they're Santa's Elves, or, should I say... Santaa's [stress  
28 the 'aa'] Elves [show Santaa video thumbnail].

## Intro

29 [Proper intro; 'hello and welcome to nguh' etc.]

## Phonology (for real this time)

30 Now, let's take a step back and take a proper look at the phoneme inventory. Now where did I  
31 put the consonants... [cut to Agma flipping through some pages trying to find a specific one] AHA  
32 THERE, there they are: Over here, we have the Elvish consonant table, this time with IPA. The Elvish  
33 consonants are: [read consonants]. See Elves have very stiff tongues and as a result are incapable of

34 articulating consonants that would require the tongue to bend to any meaningful extent. This is why  
35 the alveolar sounds are all *laminar*, that is, articulated with the *blade* rather than the tip of the tongue  
36 touching the alveolar ridge. Another consequence of this is the palato-velar series of sounds, which  
37 results from the fact that any attempt to make contact with either the palatal or velar region of the  
38 mouth results in the tongue touching nearly the entire roof of the mouth.

39 On to the vowels [show vowels table w/o click/ingressive/ogonek; do not read them yet]. Elvish vowels  
40 can be categorised into four groups. There are tense and lax variants of /a/, /i/, and /u/. The *lax* variants  
41 are written with an acute. This isn't *that* strange though. No, the interesting part is that all Elvish vowels  
42 are *ingressive* [show IPA w/ ingressive markers]. That is, we have [read ingressive vowels].

43 Now, do you know what other sounds are always ingressive? Clicks! Elvish actually has the voiceless  
44 palato-velar click, that being [attempt to pronounce /kʈ/]. Since it's ingressive, it is naturally considered  
45 a vowel as well [show slide w/ click]. Lastly, any vowel can be subscripted with an ogonek, which  
46 signifies the 'velar quality' [show slide w/ velar quality], e.g. ⟨a⟩ /a<sup>ʃg</sup>↓/.

47 Now, the crucial part here is that *only* the vowels are ingressive. The consonants are, of course, are all  
48 egressive. What this means is that speaking Elvish requires the speaker to constantly flip-flop back and  
49 forth between egressive and ingressive when articulating consonants and vowels.

## Cultural Background

50 [No slides for this one; find some nice images to show on screen for this section]

51 Now for an interlude: I'm assuming a lot of you are familiar with the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, but  
52 for anyone who isn't, it conjectures that the language we speak determines the way we think. This  
53 hypothesis is from the 1920s, and most of modern linguistics considers it to be abject nonsense, so  
54 why am I talking about this? Well, the relationship between the Elves and Elvish is the exact opposite!  
55 That is, many aspects of the Elvish language are a direct consequence of the strict rules and hierarchy  
56 of Elvish society. Thus, in order to understand Elvish, we must understand the Elves themselves.

57 So, what are Elves, really? Well, as we've established, these Elves are Santa's Elves, or rather, Santa's  
58 Elves. Every year, on the 24th night of December, The Chimney Man travels the world to distribute  
59 'gifts' among the people. The most prominent of His 'gifts' is Coal. Have you ever wondered where all  
60 of that Coal comes from? That's right, the Coal is mined by the Elves. In fact this is the only thing the  
61 Elves do: An entire society dedicated to Coal mining.

## Work Order

62 It is thus perhaps not surprising that Elves emphasise work above all else. Elvish grammar has a system  
63 much akin to animacy in other languages, and it is vital to determining word order in Elvish. The  
64 highest 'animacy', and thus primacy in a clause, goes to that which is working the hardest. This is 'Work  
65 Order' [only now, cut to the slide w/ 'Work Order']. There are 11 work orders in Elvish, numbered 1  
66 to 11, with 1 being the highest and 11 the lowest. The work orders are: [show slide w/ work orders,  
67 revealing one at a time]

68 Number 1: The Chimney Man. In any circumstance in which The Chimney Man is referenced, He  
69 will always have the highest Work Order, for He is always working the Hardest. Except for the day after  
70 Christmas, of course.

71 Number 2: Coal. Elves mine Coal, eat Coal, and breathe air laden with Coal dust. It should come as  
72 no surprise that Coal is considered the most important aspect of Elvish society and thus placed just  
73 below The Chimney Man.

74 [TODO: Move some of the more detail descriptions here elsewhere] Number 3: Master Carbonator. At  
75 the very top of Elvish society stands the council of Master Carbonators. This council consists of a dozen  
76 or so Elves who are assigned a work order of 3. The council is ruled over by the Grand Carbonator. It  
77 is the sole Elf that is assigned a work order of 2, and who is thus considered equally important to the  
78 Elves as Coal itself. The Grand Carbonator is effectively the right-hand Elf of The Chimney Man and  
79 reports to Him in person every Christmas Eve.

80 Number 4: Collier. These are highly experienced Elves that have been working in the Coal industry  
81 for at least 100 years and are typically regional overseers. Only Elves at the class of Collier or above  
82 enjoy the privilege of having their names capitalised in writing, and only they are entitled to wear *rōngi*  
83 /r̥kʰŋʲgi/ ‘cloaks’ [there is a slide for *rōngi*; it’s after all the work order slides].

84 Number 5: Head Miner. These are Elves in charge of a tunnel or Coal mine.

85 Number 6: Canary. Used for both the lowest class of Elves (that is, the common Coal miner) as well  
86 as the bird.

87 Number 7: Human Coal Miners. This is used for human Coal miners, which are regarded with more  
88 respect by the Elves than other humans.

89 Number 8: Other Human Adults. This is used for any other human adult.

90 Number 9: Animals. This is used for any animal.

91 Number 10: Human Children. This is used for human children that are not Coal miners. While  
92 important to Elvish society as the beneficiaries of their toils, they are deemed the laziest of beings.

93 Number 11: Everything Else. Generally, this is any inanimate object other than Coal, as well as abstract  
94 concepts, and so on.

95 So, this is Work Order. What does it do? Well, for starters, Work Order determines word  
96 order. That is, a noun with higher work order must precede all other nouns with lower work  
97 order within the same clause, including nested clauses. For instance, in the sentence ‘The Elf  
98 crouches on the table’ [slide], which in Elvish is *Gan nun’a gushq dun nānrú chír dāchq.*  
99 /ŋgaʰNʲ NʲuʰNʲaʰ ʝguʰŋʲaʰ d̥uʰNʲ Nʲvʰŋʲr̥uʰŋʲ ʝxiʰr̥ d̥vʰŋʲʝxaʰŋʲ./, the word for ‘Elf’, or more  
100 specifically ‘canary’, which is *nānrú* /Nʲvʰŋʲr̥uʰŋʲ/ [slide] and has work order 6 precedes the word for  
101 ‘table’ *dāchq* /d̥vʰŋʲʝxaʰŋʲ/ [slide], which has work order 11.

102 In addition to the inherent work order that every noun has, there is also another way to assign work  
103 order to nouns. This is done via a series of work order markers [slide]; these markers have the effect  
104 of raising or lowering a noun’s inherent work order by some amount. For example, take the word for  
105 ‘cane’, *dīgá* /d̥r̥ŋʲŋeʰ/ [slide], which has work order 11. Forming *xúnnq dīgá* /ʝxʰuʰNʲaʰŋʲ d̥r̥ŋʲŋeʰ/  
106 has the effect of raising the work order of *dīgá* /d̥r̥ŋʲŋeʰ/ to 5 since  $11 - 6 = 5$ ; thus, this phrase is  
107 suitable for referring to a cane that performs as much work as a Head Miner or which belongs to a  
108 Head Miner.

109 There are a few things to note here: attempting to raise or lower the work order of a noun below the  
110 minimum (w<sub>11</sub>) or above the maximum (w<sub>1</sub>) is ungrammatical [slide]. Note also the terminology:  
111 The ‘lowest’ work order is 11 and the ‘highest’ is 1, thus ‘raising’ occurs from a larger number to a



## Tense

150 There are two systems around which all of Elvish grammar revolves. One is work order, which we  
151 just discussed. The other is tense. The Elvish tense system is based on the hibernation cycle of The  
152 Chimney Man. [slide] The Chimney Man wakes up and is awake on Christmas Eve. Starting at around  
153 29 December, the Chimney Man enters REM sleep. On 4 May, He sinks into Non-REM Sleep, entering  
154 Non-REM Phase 1. This continues on 26 August, where He reaches Non-REM Phase 2, before finally  
155 sinking all the way into Non-REM Phase 3 on 10 November.

156 These five phases form the five so-called *syntactic tenses* of Elvish. They are each marked by a particle  
157 that precedes the verb. For instance, the REM Tense lasts from 29 December to 3 May. So, how exactly  
158 is this used to express time? At any point in time, the Present Tense in Elvish is whatever sleep phase  
159 The Chimney Man is in when the utterance is spoken. For instance, on 2 February, The Chimney Man  
160 is in REM sleep, and thus, the REM Sleep Tense is the Present Tense.

161 Thus, in such a sentence, the *semantic* tense is the Present Tense and the *syntactic tense* is the REM  
162 Sleep Tense; syntactic tense denotes the grammatical forms used, whereas semantic tense denotes the  
163 actual meaning. We may also say that the REM Sleep Tense is the 'syntactic Present Tense' in this  
164 context.

165 The syntactic tense following the syntactic Present Tense, in this case the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense,  
166 denotes the Future Tense, and the tense after that forms a future-in-the-future. Similarly, the syntactic  
167 tense preceding the syntactic Present Tense is the Past Tense, in this case the Awake Tense, and tense  
168 before that serves as the pluperfect.

169 But wait, what is the syntactic tense two tenses before the REM Sleep Tense if there's only the Awake  
170 Tense before it? Well, obviously, it wraps, like so [slide w/ cycle], so in this case, the syntactic Pluperfect  
171 would be the Non-REM Phase 3 Tense. What this means is that the meaning of any of the five syntactic  
172 tenses is completely dependent on the time of utterance. Thus, if you don't know when an utterance  
173 is spoken, you will have no idea how to interpret any of the tenses.

174 Recall our example sentence, 'The Elf crouches on the table' from before [slide]. The syntactic tense  
175 of this sentence is the REM Sleep Tense; thus, it only denotes a Present Tense if spoken between 29  
176 December and 3 May. If spoken on 4 May, the meaning of this sentence changes to 'The Elf crouched  
177 on the table' [slide], as the REM Sleep Tense is now the syntactic Past Tense. We would have to change  
178 the syntactic tense to the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense to preserve the original meaning [slide]. Conversely,  
179 if this new sentence was spoken on 3 May, it would instead mean 'The Elf will crouch on the table', as  
180 the Non-REM Phase 1 Tense would now be the syntactic Future Tense.

181 In written language, the choice as to what syntactic tense is the Present Tense is strictly speaking  
182 arbitrary, but by convention, it is generally that of the date on which the author wrote or started writing  
183 the text.

184 In Elvish literature, it is custom to start a text with the phrase 'This Elf declares that', with the  
185 status-appropriate abridged personal pronoun used as the subject. The syntactic tense of this phrase  
186 denotes the Present Tense for the rest of the text. E.g. if the text is written by a Collier during  
187 the REM Sleep Phase, the introductory phrase would be *Gan nun'a tú tshú'á tchá chírnú rōngi*  
188 */jgaɫN' N'wɫN'ʔaɫ tũɫ tʃhũʔɫvɫ ɕkɕxɐʔɫ ɕXIɫɫRN'wɫ ɫRkɫʃN'ʃgiɫ/*.

189 This is effectively prefixed to the first sentence of the text proper, thereby forming a new matrix clause  
190 around it. As a result, the rest of the first sentence is rendered in reported speech.

191 As an aside, when it comes to stories, poems, etc. only the written form of these texts have a fixed  
192 syntactic tense. When a story is told by an Elf, it will naturally—and indeed subconsciously without  
193 requiring active consideration or effort—rephrase the text by adjusting the syntactic tense relative to  
194 the time at which the story is told while preserving the text’s semantic tense.

195 This is further complicated during reported speech, wherein the syntactic tense is relative to the time  
196 of paraphrase rather than the time of utterance. For example, in a sentence spoken *during* the Non-  
197 REM Phase 1, the REM Sleep Tense is the syntactic Past Tense. If reported speech is used to describe  
198 or paraphrase that sentence *during* the Non-REM Phase 2, the speaker would use the Non-REM Phase  
199 1 Tense, since that is now the syntactic Past Tense.

200 Finally, if you paid close attention when I showed you the list of tenses earlier [slide], you might  
201 have noticed that there’s a gap between the Awake Tense and REM Sleep Tense that leaves a few days  
202 unaccounted for. As nobody truly knows when *exactly* the Chimney Man falls asleep, the few days  
203 following Chrismtas are an enigma to Elvish speakers. They cannot—and, out of respect and fear for  
204 the Chimney Man, will not—express anything related to time. During this time, which often spans  
205 from 25 December until 28 December, all tense marking is dropped [slide], and most Elves cease  
206 writing entirely, with the upper classes preferring to communicate in Santaa instead. This is known as  
207 the ‘Temporal Void’.

## Adjectives

208 Now that we know how tense works, we can talk about adjectives! Wait, how are those related? Well,  
209 you’ll see. Adjectives on their own are fairly simple; there is no agreement in the normal sense and  
210 they simply precede the noun they qualify. What makes adjectives complicated in Elvish is not the  
211 adjectives themselves, but rather a construct known as the ‘standalone adjective phrase’ or ‘SAP’.

212 A very common idiom in Elvish is to refer to a noun (phrase) in the domain of discourse by an adjective  
213 that describes it. These are SAPs, and they largely replace pronouns in Elvish, as while Elvish *does* have  
214 pronouns, those are only used to refer to Elves, but more on that later.

215 SAPs consist of an adjective preceded by a so-called *invoice particle*; syntactically, SAPs are treated as  
216 though they were nouns; in particular, they may be preceded by the usual noun particles and even  
217 other adjectives.

218 In writing, it is common for the first mention of a noun phrase to be accompanied by one or  
219 more adjectives that may later on be used to refer to it. For example, a fat Elf with the name  
220  $txqncu / \widehat{ck\check{x}}^{hk\downarrow f\check{g}} N^? \widehat{cku}^{f\check{g}} \downarrow /$  might be introduced as  $tx\acute{u}d\acute{i} txqncu / \widehat{ck\check{x}}^{hk\downarrow f\check{g}} \downarrow d\acute{i} \downarrow \widehat{ck\check{x}}^{hk\downarrow f\check{g}} N^? \widehat{cku}^{f\check{g}} \downarrow /$  or ‘Fat  
221  $Txqncu$ ’ and then later on referred to as  $s\acute{i} tx\acute{u}d\acute{i} / s\acute{i}^{f\check{g}} \downarrow \widehat{ck\check{x}}^{hk\downarrow f\check{g}} \downarrow d\acute{i} \downarrow /$  ‘the fat one’, where  $s\acute{i} / s\acute{i}^{f\check{g}} \downarrow /$  is one  
222 of the possible invoice particles.

223 So what is this ‘invoice particle’? The invoice operates in a similar way to adjective-noun agreement,  
224 except that it is really noun-clause agreement. That is, each noun is assigned a ‘(syntactic) tense’  
225 based on its initial phoneme [show table], and the appropriate invoice particle depends on the noun’s  
226 inherent tense as well as the syntactic tense of the clause. All syntactic tenses are assigned an integer  
227 value between 1 and 5 as you can see here [table].

228 There are five invoice particles, which are assigned an integer value between  $-2$  and  $2$ . Intuitively, the  
229 invoice particle adjusts the tense of the noun to match the syntactic tense of the clause. That is, the  
230 appropriate invoice particle for a noun is selected as follows: [slide] let  $d$  be defined as the difference  
231 of  $T(C)$  and  $T(N)$  where  $T(C)$  is the syntactic tense of the clause, and  $T(N)$  the tense of the noun.

232 The value  $v$  of the appropriate invoice particle is then given by this formula [slide], that being  $d$  if its  
 233 absolute value is less than 3, and the opposite sign of  $d$  times 5 minus the absolute value of  $d$  otherwise:

$$v := \begin{cases} d, & \text{if } |d| < 3 \\ -\text{sgn}(d) \cdot (5 - |d|), & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

234 For instance, recall our example of the fat Elf *txúdí txɔncɥ* / $\widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \widehat{\text{ck}}\text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow$ / above. The  
 235 noun *txɔncɥ* / $\widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \widehat{\text{ck}}\text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow$ / is of the Awake Tense since it starts with *tx* / $\widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{h}$ /. In a sentence in  
 236 the REM Sleep Tense, the formula above gives 1 [slide], and thus, the appropriate invoice particle is  
 237 the one with value 1, that being *sí* / $\text{s}\text{í}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow$ /, resulting in this SAP [slide].

238 By contrast, in a sentence in the Non-REM Phase 2 Tense, the formula ultimately yields  $-2$ , and thus,  
 239 the appropriate SAP is *cúr* *txúdí* / $\widehat{\text{ck}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{d}\text{í} \downarrow$ / [slide].

240 In addition to replacing pronouns, SAPs are also used to ensure a clause or phrase observes proper  
 241 work order. This phenomenon is known as *extraposition*. For instance, suppose we want to say [slide]  
 242 ‘three ferrules for the Master Carbonators under the mine’—if you don’t know what a ferrule is, it’s  
 243 this metal band here [slide] on a pickaxe.

244 Obviously, the Master Carbonators have the highest work order, so they must be  
 245 placed first. A naive translation would thus be \**ún xúsɥrɔngi tsírɔ nán tchú’i ta-rytí*  
 246 / $\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^? \widehat{\text{c}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{s}\text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{j}\text{g}\text{í} \downarrow \text{f}\text{s}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{v}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^? \widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{a} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{í} \downarrow \text{f}\text{s}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{v}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^?$ / which literally means ‘for the  
 247 Master Carbonators under the mine, three ferrules’. However, this phrase is ill-formed because *nán*  
 248 / $\text{N}^? \text{v}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^?$ / ‘mine’, a noun with work order 6, precedes *rytí* / $\text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{í} \downarrow$ / ‘ferrule’, a noun with work order 4.

249 To correct this, we need to move ‘mine’ to the end of the clause, but we can’t simply move the entire  
 250 enclosing PP as that would change the meaning of the phrase: we’d get *ún xúsɥrɔngi tchú’i ta-rytí*  
 251 *tsírɔ nán* / $\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^? \widehat{\text{c}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{s}\text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{j}\text{g}\text{í} \downarrow \widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{a} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{í} \downarrow \text{f}\text{s}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{v}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^?$ /, which means ‘three  
 252 ferrules under the mine for the Master Carbonators’—it’s now the ferrules that are under the mine and  
 253 not the Master Carbonators!

254 Instead, the proper solution is to replace the problematic noun in the PP with a SAP. The  
 255 noun is then left stranded as far back in the clause as possible, but of course preceding any  
 256 nouns with lower work order. In this case, there is no adjective qualifying the noun, so the  
 257 adjective *xún* / $\widehat{\text{c}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^?$ / is used instead. This adjective normally means ‘proper’, but in this context,  
 258 it has no meaning and only serves as an expletive, in other words to provide something the  
 259 invoice particle can be attached to. Thus, a grammatical rendition that preserves the meaning  
 260 of what we want to communicate would be *ún xúsɥrɔngi tsírɔ túr xún tchú’i ta-rytí nán*  
 261 / $\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^? \widehat{\text{c}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{s}\text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{j}\text{g}\text{í} \downarrow \text{f}\text{s}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{k}^{\text{f}}\text{f}\text{N}^? \text{t}\text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \widehat{\text{c}}\widehat{\text{x}}^{\text{h}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^? \widehat{\text{ck}}\widehat{\text{x}}\text{ú}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{a} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow \text{u}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{t}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^? \text{v}^{\text{f}}\text{g}\text{d}\text{í} \downarrow \text{N}^?$ /.

## Demonstrative Pronouns

262 As many other things, deixis in Elvish is relative: unlike other languages which employ spatial  
 263 metaphors to express time, Elvish employs temporal expressions to express relations in space. That is,  
 264 there are 5 demonstrative pronouns, each corresponding to a syntactic tense.

265 The proximal demonstrative pronoun matches the syntactic tense of the clause, the medial demon-  
 266 strative pronoun is expressed by the tense following the proximal one, and the distal demonstrative  
 267 pronoun by the tense following the medial one.

268 The pronouns are formed by combining the preposition *chír* / $\widehat{\text{c}}\widehat{\text{x}}\text{í} \downarrow \text{r}\text{r} \downarrow$ / ‘at, in, on’ with one of the tense  
 269 markers, as seen here [slide]. For example, if a clause is in the REM Sleep Tense, the demonstrative

270 pronouns are these. By contrast, if a clause is in the Non-REM Phase 2 Tense, we instead have these.  
 271 As you can see, they wrap around once we get to the Non-REM Phase 3 Tense.

272 What this means is that what to inexperienced speakers of Elvish might look like the same pronoun  
 273 might have a completely different meaning, or even be outright ungrammatical, depending on the  
 274 tense of the enclosing sentence.

275 In reported speech, the direction is reversed, i.e. instead of medial being the tense after proximal and  
 276 distal being the tense after medial, instead medial is the syntactic tense *preceding* proximal, and distal  
 277 is the tense preceding medial.

278 For example, consider a sentence uttered during the REM Sleep Phase, in which the Non-REM Phase  
 279 1 Tense is the syntactic Future Tense. In such a sentence, the medial demonstrative pronoun would  
 280 be *chíro* /ç̣x̣i↓ṛḳ†/, i.e. the Non-REM Phase 2 form; if this sentence is then paraphrased during the  
 281 Non-REM Phase 3, the syntactic Future Tense would naturally be the Awake Tense, and the medial  
 282 pronoun would be the tense *before* that (recall that the direction is reversed in reported speech); thus,  
 283 the correct form would be *chírnu* /ç̣x̣i↓ṛN²ẉṛ†/, i.e. the Non-REM Phase 3 form.

## Personal Pronouns

284 There are three sets of constructions in Elvish that are jointly referred to as ‘personal pronouns’.  
 285 While semantically equivalent, their usage is highly dependent on social status, and they are not  
 286 interchangeable.

287 The so-called *full personal pronouns* are formed by combining the demonstrative pronouns with the  
 288 status-appropriate word for ‘Elf’: The proximal demonstrative is used to express the 1st person, the  
 289 medial to express the 2nd person, and the distal to express the 3rd person. Naturally, this also means  
 290 that the exact forms of the personal pronouns depend on the syntactic tense of the containing clause  
 291 (as well as on whether direct or reported speech is used).

292 For example, in a sentence in Non-REM Phase 2 tense spoken by a Master Carbonator, the closest  
 293 Elvish equivalent to a word for ‘I’ would be *chíro xúsyṛongi* /ç̣x̣i↓ṛḳ† ç̣x̣ḥũ↓ṣẉṛ†̣ṛḳ†̣N²j̣gi↓/, lit. ‘this  
 294 Master Carbonator’. Similarly, in a sentence paraphrased in Non-REM Phase 3 tense, the word ‘it’ in  
 295 reference to a Collier would be *chírtxí isiṛongi* /ç̣x̣i↓ṛcḳç̣x̣ḥI↓ i↓ṣi↓ṛḳ†̣ṛN²j̣gi↓/, lit. ‘that (distal) Collier’.

296 In addition to the full pronouns, there are two forms of ‘abridged’ pronouns: The *high-class* abridged  
 297 pronouns are formed by combining the demonstratives with the noun *ṛongi* /ṛḳ†̣ṛN²j̣gi↓/ ‘cloak’. The  
 298 *low-class* abridged pronouns are identical to the bare demonstratives.

299 There are a few rules that constrain the use of personal pronouns in Elvish: The full pronouns are  
 300 used when speaking to someone of higher status, the abridged pronouns when speaking to someone  
 301 of equal or lower status. The high-class pronouns are used only by and in reference to Elves at the  
 302 class of Collier or Master Carbonator. The Chimney Man and The Grand Carbonator are never  
 303 referred to with pronouns. Finally, pronouns are only used to refer to Elves; SAPs are used for other  
 304 beings, objects, concepts, and so on. SAPs may also be used whenever an abridged pronoun would be  
 305 appropriate.

## Minor Grammar Notes

### Evidentiality

Now that we've discussed everything that depends on tense, we can talk about the rest of the grammar; most of these will be fairly short sections, starting with evidentiality. Evidentiality in Elvish is split into five categories: *sán* /sə↓Nʔ/, glossed VER for 'veridical', with the meaning (as though) decreed by The Chimney Man (truth); *gan* /jga↓Nʔ/, glossed OBS for 'observable', with the meaning either directly observable or deduced via reasoning; *xin* /çxʰiʃ↓Nʔ/, glossed COM for 'communicated', with the meaning communicated by someone (hearsay); *txá* /ckçxʰeʃ↓/, glossed NOR for 'North Pole', with the meaning purported to exist (in the North Pole); and finally *tsún* /tʃũxʰ↓Nʔ/, glossed DUB for 'dubious', with the meaning purported to exist elsewhere.

The 'default' evidentiality marker is generally *gan* /jga↓Nʔ/; it is commonly used for statements which the speaker considers to be true but which are not self-evident or proven facts. Statements of fact instead use the Chimney Man evidentiality—for example,  $2 + 2 = 4$ —and so do statements that an Elf is absolutely sure about. The meaning of this evidentiality is closer to 'as true as though The Chimney Man Himself had decreed it', and a suitable translation may be 'most surely'. At the same time, it is of course also used to refer to literal statements made by The Chimney Man.

### Aspect

Aspect marking differs between working verbs and lazy verbs. Working verbs are marked for telicity, i.e. whether the work is done or not. Lazy verbs are marked for whether the laziness is continued or returning. For working verbs, telic is the default, for lazy verbs, continuous is the default. Aspect markers, if present, directly precede the verb.

### Elision

When multiple verbs in a row have verb markers in common, those markers are often dropped for any verb after the first. In particular, this often applies to evidentiality markers: if the evidentiality marker of several clauses is the same, all but the first are generally dropped.

### Copula

The Elvish copula is the empty root; that is, to express the copula, all verb markers (tense, evidentiality, etc.) are used as they normally would be, except that the verb itself is 'missing'. If elision is applied, this can lead to a zero copula.

### Numbers

Elvish numbers are direct calques of Santaa's numbers. If you want to know more about this, go watch the Santaa video, but for example, the word for 7 in Elvish is *irtototqn* /i↓rʰtʰkʰfʃtʰkʰfʃtʰkʰfʃNʔ/, derived from *irgu* /i↓rʰgʷʰfʃ↓/ 'to build' and *tqn* /tʰkʰfʃNʔ/ 'more'. It literally translates to 'build more more more', which is a calque of Santaa *hō hō hō hō*.

### Appearance and Culture

Now that we've discussed Elvish grammar at length, let's talk a bit more about the Elves themselves. Let me paint you a picture: *[Literally show a timelapse of you drawing an Elf while you're explaining what Elves look like]* The body and mental state of an Elf are optimised for the mining of Coal, with all unnecessary aspects of life removed. The complexion of an Elf is a dark grey, because they are always covered in layers of Coal dust. As the Elvish eye is designed to thrive in dry and dusty environments,

339 Elves never need to close their eyes and thus lack eyelids. The only protection around their eyes is  
 340 formed by multiple layers of eye lashes, which keep the Coal dust out of their vision.

341 The throats and mouths of Elves are likewise covered in dust, making Elvish articulation extremely  
 342 hoarse and grating. Their tongues are stiff and don't bend. Elves also have no lips, making their sharp  
 343 and pointy teeth, which are perpetually stained black by the consumption of Coal, clearly visible; it is  
 344 for this reason that Elvish lacks labial sounds and rounded vowels.

345 Elves have inverted knees, which improves crawling in tunnel conditions. Their ears are pointy, but  
 346 they point downwards to avoid colliding with the low ceiling of their mines; to that end, lower-class  
 347 Elves are also almost always hunched down so as to fit in even lower tunnels. Elves are mostly bald,  
 348 the most hair they have on their bodies is their eye lashes.

349 Lastly, Elves have no gender and are all referred to as 'it'. They do not, and for that matter, cannot,  
 350 reproduce and are instead all created by The Chimney Man.

## Elvish Upper Class

351 The social classes of Collier and Master Carbonator comprise the upper classes of Elvish society; these  
 352 Elves are easily identified as only they are entitled to wear *rŋngi* /r̥ŋ<sup>k+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ŋgi↓/ 'cloaks'. These cloaks  
 353 come in three forms:

- 354 ◇ Colliers wear crimson cloaks and are thus commonly referred to as *isirŋngi* /i↓s̥i↓r̥ŋ<sup>k+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ŋgi↓/  
 355 'redcloaks'.
- 356 ◇ Master Carbonators wear crimson cloaks embroidered with black patterns of Coal and are thus  
 357 commonly referred to as *xúsyrŋngi* /ç̥x<sup>h</sup>ũ↓s̥u<sup>ŋ</sup>ŋgi↓r̥ŋ<sup>k+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ŋgi↓/ 'blackcloaks'.
- 358 ◇ Finally, the Grand Carbonator's cloak is entirely black and coated with Coal; for this reason, the  
 359 Grand Carbonator is commonly referred to as *Shŋnxarŋngi* /ʂ<sup>hk+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ç̥x<sup>h</sup>a<sup>ŋ</sup>ŋgi↓r̥ŋ<sup>k+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ŋgi↓/ 'Coal cloak'.

360 Other Elves do not wear any clothes at all. The common Elf instead keeps itself warm in the freezing  
 361 temperatures of the Arctic by burning the Coal it consumes inside its ventral furnace. Some lower-  
 362 class Elves may attempt to pretend to have a higher social class than they actually do; such Elves are  
 363 referred to as *ishúrŋngi* /i↓s̥hũ↓r̥ŋ<sup>k+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ŋgi↓/ 'fake cloaks'. Wearing a cloak that corresponds to a higher  
 364 class than one's own is generally punished by decommissioning.

## 'Retirement'

365 A central concept in Elvish society is *shúnq* /ʂ<sup>h</sup>ũ<sup>ŋ</sup>ŋ<sup>a</sup>ŋgi↓/ 'retirement'. Elves never stop working; that  
 366 is, an Elf only 'retires' at the moment of its death. In some cases, Elves who have acted out of line or  
 367 otherwise disrupted the Coal mining process—or worse, slighted The Chimney Man—can be 'decom-  
 368 missioned', which entails *actively* 'retiring' an Elf. This is also known as 'dishonourable retirement'.

369 Elves that retire honourably are given a *Shŋnxqshúnq* /ʂ<sup>hk+ŋ</sup>N<sup>?</sup>ç̥x<sup>h</sup>a<sup>ŋ</sup>ŋgi↓ʂ<sup>h</sup>ũ<sup>ŋ</sup>ŋ<sup>a</sup>ŋgi↓/ 'Coal burial', i.e. they  
 370 are cremated in such a way as to turn them into Coal, thus contributing to Elvish society even after  
 371 their demise.

## Refurbishment

372 Refurbishment is the act of promoting an Elf from a lower social class into a higher social class; this  
 373 is a rare occurrence and only awarded to Elves for distinguished acts of service in the mines. For

instance, a canary that consistently delivers twice the amount of Coal compared to its co-workers may be promoted to head miner after some time once new tunnels are constructed.

376 Upon becoming a Collier or Master Carbonator, an Elf is rewarded with a *rongi* /rŋ<sup>k+ŋ</sup>ŋgi/ ‘cloak’,  
377 which is subsequently sewn onto it, thus completing the refurbishment process and clearly demar-  
378 cating them as now part of a higher social class than its former peers.

Below the class of Collier, candidates for refurbishment are selected by Colliers. Candidates for the class of Collier are selected by the Master Carbonators, and candidates for the latter class directly by The Grand Carbonator. An Elf cannot become The Grand Carbonator. If The Grand Carbonator retires, a new one is constructed by The Chimney Man.

383 Lastly, refurbishment has no corresponding opposite process: if an Elf does something that causes it  
384 to fall below its social class, only decommissioning awaits it.

## Translation

The following is an Elvish rendition of JRR Tolkien's Ring Verse, as translated and adapted by the Elvish poet *Tōrxí* /<sup>t̪ox̥i</sup>/ṛ̥x̥h̥ɪ/; Elves of course don't wear rings, so the verse refers to ferrules instead. Other parts of the poem that would have likewise been unfamiliar to the common Canary have been replaced with more Elvish concepts as well. Without further ado: [\[read translation\]](#)

## Sentence Analysis

389 Finally, let's take a closer look at one of the sentences of the translation as it serves as a good example  
390 of some of the quirks of Elvish grammar. The sentence in question is *Ūrú gan txadâ cuncuton ún dun*  
391 *câ sán túsâ úxî shanú dun túr shardo núgí*, lit. 'that there are nine for mortal men doomed to retire'.

The marker /ʉ́rɪ́/ /ũ̃<sup>ǵ</sup>↓ṛũ̃<sup>ǵ</sup>↓/ marks that the entire clause is an object of the verb *tshú'á* /t͡ʂʰũ̃<sup>h</sup>↓v̥↓/ ‘declare’ in the first clause of the poem. It can be translated as the English subordinator ‘that’ in this context.

395 The evidentiality marker *gan* /jgaNʔ/ qualifies the copula, which has no root. It is required here to  
396 prevent *úrú* from affecting only the following noun phrase, as it must precede a verb (marker) to affect  
397 the entire clause.

398 *txadq̄ cuncutōn* /*ck̄x̄<sup>ha</sup>↓d̄e<sup>ḡ</sup>↓ ck̄w̄↓N'ck̄w̄↓t̄<sup>k</sup>↓ḡN'?* is simply the word for the number 9 (whose default  
399 work order is 11) raised by 7 work orders to give it work order 4 to match *ruṭí* /*r̄ṭw̄<sup>ḡ</sup>↓t̄<sup>ḡ</sup>↓t̄<sup>ḡ</sup>↓* 'ferrule' in  
400 the a preceding clause, which is elided here. Thus, this phrase literally means 'nine of the thing with  
401 work order 4'.

402 The complement of the PP headed by *ún* /úŋN/ 'for' is the rest of the clause.

403 The relative clause *dun cq sán túsq úxí shaní dun túr shardo* ‘which are destined to retire’ is fairly  
 404 complicated on its own. The relative clauses in Elvish *precede* the noun they modify, which in this case is  
 405 *shardo núgí* /s<sup>h</sup>a↓rɒd<sup>k</sup> n<sup>ʔ</sup>ú↓gɪ<sup>ʃ</sup>↓/ ‘mortal humans’. Notably, the relative pronoun *cq* /čka<sup>ʃ</sup>↓/ is not the  
 406 first word in the clause. Rather, because it is the subject of a clause with a lazy verb, it is preceded by  
 407 the lazy agent marker *dun* /du↓n<sup>ʔ</sup>/.

408 The complement of *túsq* /tũ↓sə<sup>ŋ</sup>↓/ ‘to be destined’ is yet another clause, viz. *shqnú dun túr shardo*  
 409 ‘the mortal ones retire.’ This inner clause is preceded by the lazy theme marker *úxí* /ũ↓x<sup>h</sup>í<sup>ŋ</sup>↓/, which  
 410 marks that the clause is the theme of *túsq* /tũ↓sə<sup>ŋ</sup>↓/.

411 The sequence *túr shardo núgí* /túr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup> s̥<sup>h</sup>a↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup>d<sup>k</sup>† n<sup>ʔ</sup>úr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓g<sup>ǵ</sup>↓/ is actually short for *túr shardo shardo*  
412 *núgí* /túr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup> s̥<sup>h</sup>a↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup>d<sup>k</sup>† s̥<sup>h</sup>a↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup>d<sup>k</sup>† n<sup>ʔ</sup>úr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓g<sup>ǵ</sup>↓/. That is, we have a SAP *túr shardo* /túr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup> s̥<sup>h</sup>a↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup>d<sup>k</sup>†/  
413 ‘the mortal ones’, which agrees with *núgí* /n<sup>ʔ</sup>úr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓g<sup>ǵ</sup>↓/ ‘human’, followed by the noun *shardo núgí*  
414 /s̥<sup>h</sup>a↓r̥<sup>ǵ</sup>d<sup>k</sup>† n<sup>ʔ</sup>úr<sup>ǵ</sup>↓g<sup>ǵ</sup>↓/ ‘mortal humans’, which is also the referent of the SAP.

415 In such situations, that is, when a SAP is followed immediately by its referent, it is not uncommon for  
416 the same adjective to appear twice in a row (since it is both part of the SAP and also modifies the noun).  
417 This is rather awkward, so Elvish instead contracts the two into a single instance of the adjective. This  
418 phenomenon is known as *SAP contraction*. It is fairly easily identified as the sequence ‘invoice marker  
419 + adjective + noun’ isn’t otherwise valid in Elvish.

420 So in sum, this sentence is a dependent clause that acts as the theme of a preceding clause and which  
421 contains a relative clause whose theme is yet *another* clause, and both inner clauses either modify or  
422 reference a noun that occurs later on in the sentence.

## Outro

423 [Outro]